





A DARK REALITY
(Clockwise from left) Hrithik Roshan in *Super 30*, Komal Kushwahaa in *Dupahiya* and Bhumi Pednekar in *Bala*

lead, the opposite does not happen. Southern cinema, particularly Tamil and Telugu films, have seen an influx of light-skinned actresses, some of them even imported from outside the country, who are cast opposite the dark-skinned leading men. Think Amy Jackson.

Television, on the other hand, has been better at creating and casting for narratives that touch upon the issue. So much so that it has become a playbook of sorts. ZEE TV show *Saat Phere–Saloni Ka Safar* (2005–2009) was one of the earliest to showcase the societal pressures and prejudices against darker people, making a star out of its lead actress, Rajashree Thakur. This, in turn, would lead to Star Plus launching a show of their own—*Sapna Baabul Ka... Bidaai* (2007–2010)—on the same subject. One of Dangal TV channel's most popular shows, *Mann Sundar* (2021–), started off featuring its protagonist not caring a whit about her dark skin.

Though slow, change is coming to the film industry too. Casting director Tess Joseph, for instance, pushes back when film production houses want to cast on colourist lines. "Change is a decision you make and push for," she says. Others hope to realistically portray what it's like to deal with the insecurities of darker-skinned people. In the Amazon Prime series *Dupahiya* (2025), an educated woman (newcomer Komal Kushwahaa) in a fictional village is eager to get a brightening treatment to improve her prospects. For Chirag Garg, the show's co-writer, it was an opportunity to discuss how the desire for fair skin continues to play on the minds of India's brightest. "In the villages, people are more in-your-face about it; in cities, it could be a subtext," says Garg. Having witnessed first-hand the industry's obsession with fair skin colour during auditions, Garg feels change will be a gradual process. "Ultimately, it should be your talent and skill set, not colour or caste or creed, which get you far."



"Inclusivity meant challenging the visual representation in beauty advertising. From Day 1, we ensured we featured real, diverse Indian skin tones in our campaigns"

GHAZAL ALAGH, *Co-founder, Honasa Consumer*

their founder Karishma Kewalramani.

There is still some way to go, though. "Campaigns by celebrities can only be on the surface and a start," says Parameswaran, "they have not gone deep into the caste and class consciousness of the Indian psyche." She believes sensitisation to social and workplace discrimination based on colourism and sexism needs to start early, in elementary school perhaps, "not in a chance workshop after you are an adult and have weathered much trauma." Brands, says an expert from the beauty and personal care industry who does not want to be named, need to do more than just pay lip service to inclusion. They may have a model with a dark skin tone in their promotions, but that inclusion is not visible in their product range. Even today, they may launch 15 light to medium foundations but have just four in the deep to tan skin tones.

Others are even advocating 'skin neutrality', or treating the skin as just another organ and not drawing attention to it at all. Many celebrities, from Selena Gomez to Shanaya Kapoor and Alia Bhatt, have been posting selfies free of make-up, filters and touch-ups to show that they too have blemishes and not so perfect skins. Of course one can still have negative thoughts about their skin colour, particularly if they have been subjected to colourism. But it is a step towards not hating yourself for your skin colour, rather making your peace with it, and celebrating it. ■

–with Sonal Khetarpal